

Prologue

Fairy tales have similar beginnings and depending on what comes after the familiar, "Once upon a time," we know who and what the story is about. Parenting can often seem like everyone else knows what comes next except you!

"I think something happened to my child but I'm not sure. How do I ask them without, you know, freaking them out?" "We're really trying to be like Christ raising our children but, I never could have even looked like I wanted to say something when my parents were talking to me and these kids nowadays, wow!!" "I'm trying, but my kids don't seem like they want to talk to me."

At the time we write this book our children are ages 23, 21, 15 and 14. After 24 years of marriage we don't know everything and our children aren't perfect but we've learned some valuable lessons through the years.

Fundamental to everything we share is a transformation of heart (**Matthew 12:34; Luke 6:45**). Skills and techniques won't change what or who I am in heart. Words that uplift and heal and restore come from renewed people. The renewed person must grow in the new way of life while suppressing the cravings of the old life (**2 Peter 3:18; Colossians 4:6; Ephesians 4:15; James 3:1-12**). **This small volume assumes readers have this experience as part of their journey.**

This book is our attempt to share a few of the things we've gathered along the way in our journey of parenting.

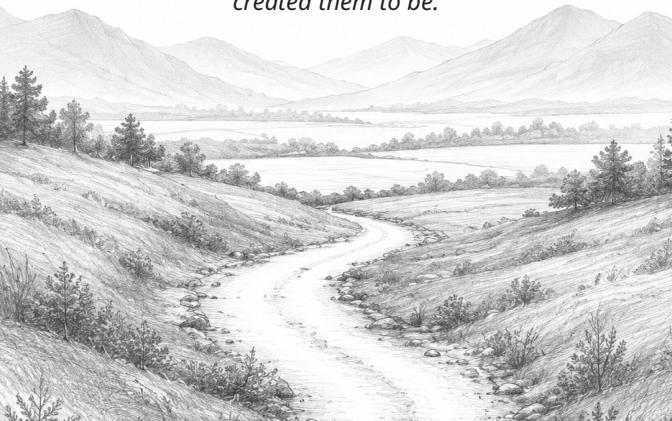
Our primary desire is that you have a healthy relationship with your children that manifest itself in the ability to have even the most difficult conversations with them. By God's grace some of the things we share with you in the next pages help you to get there.

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OUT OF THE SHADOWS



*Parenting begins by seeing
your child for who God
created them to be.*



First things first. Are you the most important consideration when it comes to raising your child/children? Your values, your faith, your boundaries? How we answer this question greatly influences our approach to parenting. I'm going to suggest the answer to this question is NO!

- **Consider you inherit a foundry furnace. These furnaces are designed for melting metal to be poured into molds to create cast parts.**
- **Consider you inherit a sawmill. These produce a variety of lumber and wood based products. Commonly their output includes dimensional lumber, timbers, and boards. Along with byproducts such as wood chips and saw dust and bark.**

The outcome in each of these business ventures is more determined by the raw materials that go in then by the tools they have on hand. What will be produced by placing wood in a furnace? How about metal in a sawmill?

Yet this is how so many approach parenting. "It was good enough for me, should be good enough for you." What this yields are burned out children and worn down parents. We call it shadow parenting. This occurs when we place parenting style above the uniqueness of the child. There are generally two ways parents get here.

Lima beans for some strange reason were

the bane of my existence as a child. Something about there texture didn't agree with my stomach from 1-12 years old. I recall sitting at the table for over an hour staring at the small pile of beans on my plate with the direction I was not to move till each one of them was gone! I vowed to myself never to make my children eat Lima beans.

Negative experiences with our families is a primary means of getting into shadow parenting. We so despised what was done or neglected to be done, in our own experience, a promise is made regarding how we will relate in these areas to our own sons and daughters.

Positive experiences as well as positive perspectives on our upbringing also often serve as the catalyst for shadow parenting. My experience was so good or right I will make sure my children have the same things I did!

Neither of these examples is a denial of what you experienced and the impact it had on you. However we must remember you are not your child! Hand planes, scrapers, rasps, and sand paper may have been appropriate for smoothing your rough edges, but your daughter may need the heat of a furnace.

One author suggest, *"parents become acquainted with their children, seeking to understand their tastes, and dispositions, entering into their feelings, and drawing out what is in their*

hearts.” Parenting our children for who they are instead of who we are and were or worse yet who are parents are or weren’t is how we come out of the shadows.

Summary

How we were raised, what our parents did right or wrong, should not be the most important considerations in raising our children. Our children, and who they are, should be more important than these other considerations.



Think About It

Prayerfully reflect on the questions below. Be honest with yourself, write your thoughts, and ask God to reveal what He wants you to learn and apply.

- 1.** Are you acquainted with your child/children?
- 2.** Share with your spouse/friend your perspective on your child’s dispositions, tastes, their feelings.
- 3.** Have you experienced shadow parenting, explain?
- 4.** Which do you believe is closer to your child’s needs? Furnace, Sawmill, Canal System